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The Home Food Business Playbook

Start and grow a tiffin service, home bakery or cloud kitchen from your own kitchen - legally, profitably and without surprises.

INDIA 2026-27 EDITION

Rs. 1.5 cr
New FSSAI registration ceiling (from Rs. 12 lakh)

25%
Growth in tiffin searches, year to April 2026

Rs. 100/yr
FSSAI Basic Registration fee - now perpetual

Every rule verified from FSSAI, CBIC, the MSME Ministry, MoFPI, MUDRA and the Income Tax Department - October 2026

About This Guide

This is a working playbook for starting a food business from your own kitchen in India - a tiffin or dabba service, a home bakery, or a delivery-only cloud kitchen - and running it legally, profitably, and without nasty surprises.

It is written for first-time founders: homemakers turning a family recipe into income, students and young professionals testing a side business, and anyone already selling on WhatsApp or Instagram who now wants to do it properly and grow.

Every rule here is built from primary sources - FSSAI's 2026 licensing reform and the FoSCoS portal, the CGST Act and CBIC circulars, the MSME Ministry's Udyam system, MoFPI's PMFME scheme, MUDRA, and the Income-tax Act. Fees, thresholds and dates are stated as they stand in October 2026, and each chapter names its source so you can check it yourself.

Three things to hold in mind as you read:

- Rules move. Fees and thresholds change - always confirm the current figure on the official portal before you pay anything.
- This is not legal, tax or food-safety advice. For your own situation, confirm with a chartered accountant or a food-safety consultant.
- The numbers in the worked examples are illustrative models, not promises. Your margin depends on your city, your menu and your discipline.

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Part 1 - The Opportunity, and Why 2026-27 Is the Year

Home-cooked food became a real market

The demand is not a guess. Searches for tiffin services on Justdial rose 25% across India between May 2025 and April 2026, led by Lucknow at 33% and Delhi at 31%. The organised tiffin and meal-subscription segment is estimated at over Rs. 25,000 crore and growing 15-20% a year. India's overall food service market was about Rs. 7.5 lakh crore in 2025 and is projected to reach Rs. 12.3 lakh crore by 2030.

Two shifts sit behind those numbers. Urban households are smaller and busier, so fewer people cook every meal at home. And the platforms that once served only restaurants - Swiggy, Zomato, and now the government-backed ONDC network - have opened onboarding to home kitchens. A cook with a good menu and a licence can now reach customers without a shopfront.

25%

Tiffin search growth

India, year to April 2026 (Justdial analysis, June 2026)

Rs. 25,000 cr+

Tiffin segment

Growing 15-20% a year (Restaurant India, 2026)

Rs. 12.3 lakh cr

Food service by 2030

Up from about Rs. 7.5 lakh crore in 2025

The April 2026 FSSAI reform changed the maths

For years, the single biggest brake on a home food business was the licence ladder. FSSAI's Basic Registration covered turnover only up to Rs. 12 lakh a year. Cross that - which a busy tiffin service does quickly - and you had to move to a State Licence, which meant a commercial-kitchen inspection and a much larger fee.

That changed on 1 April 2026. FSSAI notified the Food Safety and Standards (Licensing and Registration of Food Businesses) Amendment Regulations, 2026 (Gazette notification dated 10 March 2026), and an order dated 13 March 2026 raised the registration ceiling from Rs. 12 lakh to Rs. 1.5 crore. In plain terms: a home kitchen can now grow from a few thousand rupees a month to Rs. 1.5 crore a year on the same Rs. 100-a-year registration, with no commercial kitchen inspection. The same reform made FSSAI registrations and licences perpetually valid - the old renewal cycle is gone.

What this means for you

You no longer need to plan your growth around a licence upgrade at Rs. 12 lakh. Most home food businesses will run their entire growth story - first customer to a seven-figure business - inside a single Basic Registration.

The three models, compared

Model	What you sell	Best for	Licence
Tiffin / dabba service	Fixed weekly or monthly meal subscriptions on a delivery route	Predictable recurring revenue; cooks with a set rotating menu	Basic Registration
Home bakery	Cakes, cookies, mithai and packaged bakes made to order	Instagram-first sellers with strength in one product	Basic Registration (State if scaling to retail)
Cloud kitchen from home	Delivery-only menu through apps and direct orders	Cooks who want app reach and higher order volume	Basic Registration; some apps ask for State licence on high-risk menus

Most people start with one and add the others later. A tiffin cook adds weekend cakes; a baker adds a corporate gifting line; a cloud kitchen adds a subscription tier. The legal stack is the same for all three, which is why we build it once, properly, in Part 3.

What it takes to succeed

- A product people reorder. In a subscription business one good meal is worth little; the tenth reorder is the whole business.
- Discipline on cost. Home food businesses fail on unmeasured food cost and delivery, not on cooking.
- Paperwork done early. A licence you hold before you sell is cheap; one you get after a complaint is a penalty.
- A tight delivery radius. Hot food and a single-run route decide whether you profit or lose money on every order.

Part 2 - Choose Your Idea and Prove There Is Demand

Start with one product, not a menu

The most common early mistake is a long menu. A 25-item list makes costing impossible, slows your cooking, and gives customers no reason to remember you. Pick one narrow, specific product and own it. Three examples that work in India: a single-cuisine lunch tiffin for PG and hostel students in one locality; eggless custom cakes for birthdays and small offices; a South Indian breakfast subscription for a corporate park.

Narrow is not small. A tight product is easier to cook consistently, easier to cost, and easier for one happy customer to describe to a friend in a single sentence - which is how home food businesses actually grow.

The 7-day validation sprint

Before you spend on equipment or a licence, spend seven days testing whether people will pay. This is the cheapest insurance you will ever buy.

1. **Day 1 - Define the customer and the geography.** Write one sentence: for whom, in which two or three pin codes, at what meal time.
2. **Day 2 - Count the competition.** Search your pin code on Swiggy and Zomato, and check Justdial and local WhatsApp groups. Note how many home kitchens already serve your idea.
3. **Day 3 - Price from the market, not your feelings.** Record what the nearest three competitors charge per meal or per cake, and what they include.
4. **Day 4 - Cook for five paying testers.** Take prepaid orders from friends-of-friends - never free. Free food tells you nothing.
5. **Day 5 - Ask two blunt questions.** Would you order this again next week? What would make you stop? Write down the exact words.
6. **Day 6 - Run the numbers.** Estimate your cost per unit (Part 5) and check whether the market price leaves a real margin after packaging and delivery.
7. **Day 7 - Decide.** If four of five testers would reorder and the margin works, proceed. If not, change the product, not the price.

> **The only metric that matters at this stage**
>
> Repeat intent. A stranger who says 'I would order this again' is worth more than ten polite compliments. Build on reorders, not on first orders.

A one-page business canvas

Fill this in before you register anything. It becomes the reference you return to every month.

Block	Your answer
Who exactly is my customer?	e.g. working bachelors in two PG clusters, lunch only
What single product do I sell?	e.g. one veg thali, rotating dal and sabzi, 5 days a week
What is my price?	e.g. Rs. 2,800 a month for lunch, 22 days
What does one unit cost me?	e.g. Rs. 58 all-in (Part 5 breaks this down)
How do I reach them?	e.g. direct WhatsApp route plus one app listing

Block	Your answer
What is my first-week goal?	e.g. 15 paying subscribers, 90% on-time delivery
What could stop me?	e.g. society NOC delay, delivery distance, one ingredient price spike

Read the local demand signals

Demand is hyperlocal, so read your own streets rather than national averages. A dense pocket of PGs, hostels or a large office campus within a two-kilometre radius is the classic first customer base, because one delivery run serves many people. Fewer than three competitors in that radius, and a population that eats out daily, is a green light. A saturated pocket where five kitchens already fight on price is a red light - either pick a different pocket or a genuinely different product.

Part 3 - The Legal Stack, in the Right Order

Order matters, and getting it wrong is expensive. Every year, home cooks sign a rental agreement, buy equipment, and only then discover they cannot list on an app or cannot legally cook commercially in their flat. Work through these five steps in sequence.

1. FSSAI registration - the food licence, mandatory before your first sale.
2. Udyam (MSME) registration - free, and the key to every government benefit.
3. Local permissions - society or landlord consent, and any municipal trade licence.
4. GST - only once the law says you need it.
5. Labelling - before you sell any packaged item with a sticker on it.

Step 1: FSSAI registration on FoSCoS

Any person who manufactures, stores, sells or distributes food must be registered or licensed under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006. There is no exemption for cooking from home - a home baker selling ten cakes a week needs it just as a restaurant does. Selling without it attracts punishment under Section 63 of the Act: imprisonment up to six months and a fine up to Rs. 5 lakh (raised to a penalty of up to Rs. 10 lakh by the Jan Vishwas (Amendment) Act, 2023).

Your tier is decided purely by annual turnover, using the thresholds FSSAI set from 1 April 2026:

Tier	Annual turnover (from 1 Apr 2026)	Typical user	Government fee
Basic Registration	Up to Rs. 1.5 crore	Home tiffin, home bakery, small kitchen	Rs. 100
State Licence	Above Rs. 1.5 crore to Rs. 50 crore	Growing cloud kitchen, catering unit	Rs. 5,000
Central Licence	Above Rs. 50 crore	Large manufacturer, multi-state operator	Rs. 7,500

Fees and tiers per FSSAI order dated 13 March 2026 and the FoSCoS Kind-of-Business eligibility sheet (updated April 2026). Confirm the current fee on foscos.fssai.gov.in before you pay.

The FoSCoS walkthrough

1. Create an account at foscos.fssai.gov.in with your mobile number and email.
2. Choose 'Apply for Registration / License' and select Basic Registration for turnover up to Rs. 1.5 crore.
3. Pick your Kind of Business - for a home kitchen that is typically 'Food Service' / 'Petty Retailer' / 'Hawker' depending on how you sell - and your state and district.
4. Fill Form B: your details, business name, food category (cooked food, bakery, snacks and so on), and your home address as the business address.
5. Upload a photo ID (Aadhaar, PAN or Voter ID), a passport-size photo, address proof (electricity bill or rent agreement), and a self-declaration that you will follow hygiene rules.
6. Pay the fee online and track the application. Basic Registration is usually approved within about 7-30 working days; you receive the certificate and a 14-digit FSSAI number by email.

Perpetual validity - what it actually means

Since 1 April 2026, FSSAI registrations and licences stay valid unless suspended, cancelled or surrendered - you no longer renew every one to five years. The annual fee still applies, and you must keep meeting hygiene rules. Registrations issued before the reform keep their original renewal dates until migrated on FoSCoS.

Documents to keep ready

Document	Where it comes from	Why it matters
Photo ID (Aadhaar, PAN or Voter ID)	You already have it	Identity of the applicant
Passport-size photograph	Recent	Printed on the certificate
Address proof	Electricity bill, gas bill or rent agreement	Proves your home address
List of food products	Your menu	Sets your Kind of Business category
Hygiene self-declaration	FoSCoS application form	Confirms you will follow Schedule 4
Society or landlord consent	Society office or property owner	Not FSSAI, but the real local gate

What the FSSAI officer actually checks

The reform moved most new registrations to instant approval, but risk-based inspection still exists, and a complaint can trigger a visit. An officer typically looks at whether the kitchen is clean and free of pests, whether the water is potable, whether utensils and containers are food-grade, whether your packaging carries the correct label and FSSAI number, and whether you keep enough records to trace a batch. None of it is exotic - it is the seven Schedule 4 habits from Part 4, done consistently.

Step 2: Udyam (MSME) registration

Udyam registration is free, paperless, and needs only your Aadhaar. It gives your business an official MSME identity and unlocks benefits that a licence alone does not: priority-sector lending, credit-guarantee cover, protection against delayed payments, and access to government procurement. The government has set aside 25% of its procurement for MSMEs, including 3% reserved for women-owned enterprises. Under the classification revised on 1 April 2025, a micro enterprise is one with investment up to Rs. 2.5 crore and turnover up to Rs. 10 crore - which covers virtually every home food business.

Benefit	What it gets you
Priority-sector lending	Banks must lend a share to MSMEs; registration puts you in that queue
Credit guarantee (CGTMSE)	Collateral-free cover for eligible loans; women-led firms get enhanced cover
Delayed-payment protection	Buyers must pay within 45 days; complaints go to the MSME Samadhaan portal
Government tenders (GeM)	Sell to government buyers on the GeM marketplace
Scheme eligibility	Required or preferred for PMFME, MUDRA and most MSME programmes

Register at udyamregistration.gov.in - the only official portal. Beware of lookalike sites that charge a fee for a free service.

Step 3: Local permissions nobody warns you about

FSSAI makes your food legal. It does not make your flat a legal place to run a business from - that is decided locally, and it is where most home kitchens are quietly stopped.

- **Housing-society consent.** Most societies restrict commercial activity and can fine members. If you rent, your standard agreement probably bars commercial use - get the owner's written consent on society letterhead, naming your flat and the activity.

- **Municipal commercial-use rules.** Rules on running a business from a residential unit vary by city. Some municipalities are relaxed for small kitchens; a complaint can still trigger a notice.
- **Trade licence.** Several cities - Hyderabad, Bengaluru, Mumbai among them - ask for a municipal trade licence when you list on Swiggy or Zomato, even for a home kitchen. Fees are typically a few hundred to a few thousand rupees.
- **Shop and Establishment registration.** Required once you hire staff; a small state fee.

> **Do this before you spend on equipment**
>
> Have the society-NOC conversation first. A society that will not consent ends the business faster than any licence delay - and far more cheaply if you find out early.

Step 4: GST - only when the rule says so

GST confuses home cooks more than any other rule, because two different things are true at once.

First, restaurant service - and a cloud kitchen is treated as a restaurant - is taxed at 5% with no input tax credit. Since 1 January 2022, Swiggy and Zomato are 'electronic commerce operators' for restaurant supply under Section 9(5) of the CGST Act: on app orders, the platform collects the 5% from the customer and pays it to the government on your behalf. You do not collect or remit it yourself for those orders.

Second, you do not have to register for GST just because you sell through an app. Section 24(ix) - which forces e-commerce sellers to register regardless of turnover - expressly excludes supplies notified under Section 9(5), and restaurant service through Swiggy and Zomato is one of them. You register only when your aggregate turnover crosses the threshold: Rs. 20 lakh a year for services (Rs. 10 lakh in special-category states).

Question	The position in 2026
GST rate on my food	5% as restaurant service, no input tax credit
Who pays it on app orders	The platform, under the Section 9(5) mechanism
Do I register just to list on an app?	No - Section 9(5) supplies are outside the mandatory rule
When must I register?	When turnover crosses Rs. 20 lakh (Rs. 10 lakh in special-category states)
GST on the platform's commission	18% - a real cost you absorb, and cannot offset at 5%

In October 2026 CBIC clarified that delivery services provided through e-commerce platforms were reduced from 18% to 5% under the 57th GST Council - so there is no new tax on food delivery, only a lower one. Platforms may still ask for a GSTIN as a commercial condition, or an exemption declaration if you are below the threshold. Food, unlike many goods, is a service for GST, so the Rs. 20 lakh services threshold applies.

Step 5: Labelling your packaged food

Cooked meals eaten the same day need little labelling. But the moment you sell a packaged item - cookies in a box, a jar of pickle, a sealed cake - the Food Safety and Standards (Labelling and Display) Regulations, 2020 apply in full. Every package sold commercially should carry:

- Your 14-digit FSSAI registration or licence number, and the FSSAI logo in a contrasting colour.
- The name of the food and a complete ingredient list, in descending order of weight.
- Net weight or volume, and the date of manufacture with a best-before or use-by date.

- The veg or non-veg symbol - a green dot for vegetarian, brown for non-vegetarian - on the front of the pack. This one cannot be skipped even on very small packs.
- Your name and address as the food business operator, and allergen declarations where relevant.
- Storage instructions if the product needs specific conditions.

Very small packs (surface area up to 100 square centimetres) are exempt from some logos - but not from the veg or non-veg mark, which FSSAI treats as a matter of informed choice. Print your FSSAI number on your menus, invoices and app listings too.

The seven registration traps

- Starting to sell before the FSSAI number is in hand - a fine is cheaper than the lost trust.
- Using a borrowed or fake FSSAI number, which is a serious offence.
- Assuming a home address cannot be an FSSAI address. It can, and usually is.
- Signing a lease or buying equipment before checking society and municipal rules.
- Registering for GST you do not need, then carrying its compliance cost forever.
- Listing on an app with a licence whose name does not match your PAN or bank account - the most common onboarding rejection.
- Forgetting the annual FSSAI fee after perpetual validity - missing it can trigger deemed suspension and pull your app listing.

Part 4 - Your Kitchen, Set Up Right

Equipment, in three budget tiers

You already own the most expensive asset - the kitchen. Everything else scales with your model. The table below shows a realistic starting spend; buy the middle tier only once orders are steady.

Item	Starter (Rs. 8k-15k)	Growing (Rs. 25k-50k)	Scaled (Rs. 1L+)
Cooking vessels and utensils	Extra kadai, tawa, pressure cooker	Commercial burners, large stock pots	Two-burner commercial range, bulk vessels
Refrigeration	Existing fridge	Second fridge or small deep-freezer	Chest freezer, cold storage
Packaging	Steel tiffin boxes, paper bags	Branded boxes, food-grade containers, insulated bags	Sealing machine, custom-printed packs
Delivery	Own scooter or on-foot route	Insulated carrier boxes, second scooter	Dedicated rider or part-time driver
Licence and registration	FSSAI Rs. 100, Udyam free	Municipal trade licence	State FSSAI if turnover crosses Rs. 1.5 cr

Cost ranges are typical market estimates for 2026 and vary by city. Do not buy the growing tier before your first ten repeat customers.

Hygiene: FSSAI Schedule 4 in plain English

Schedule 4 of the FSSAI licensing regulations sets the hygiene expectations for every food business, home kitchens included. In practice, the rules reduce to seven habits:

1. Clean premises: surfaces cleaned before and after cooking, and the kitchen kept free of pests, rodents and pets.
2. Safe water: use potable water for cooking, washing and ice.
3. Personal hygiene: wash hands, tie back hair, and never cook when unwell.
4. Temperature control: keep hot food above 60 degrees C until dispatch; do not leave cooked food at room temperature for more than two hours.
5. Food-grade containers only: no reused non-food plastic; sealed, lidded packs.
6. Separation: store raw meat, fish and eggs away from cooked food and vegetables.
7. Traceability: keep simple records of what you cooked, when, and for whom.

Packaging that travels and complies

- Choose containers that hold heat and do not leak - a good insulated carrier matters more than an expensive box.
- Use a label or sticker with product name, date, FSSAI number and your contact; for packaged goods add ingredients, net weight and the veg or non-veg mark.
- Match the pack to the journey: gravies, dals and rice travel well; fried and crisp items do not.
- Keep packaging cost in your per-unit maths - it is the cost most first-timers forget.

Storage, waste and cold chain

Buy for the week, not the day, to cut cost - but only what you can store safely. Cook in batches where the product allows, cool quickly, and refrigerate within two hours. Track waste for one week and you will usually find the single ingredient that is quietly eating your margin. For a home bakery, invest early in proper cooling racks and airtight storage; for a tiffin service, portion control at the point of packing is what keeps cost per meal honest.

Part 5 - Pricing and Unit Economics

Cost per meal: the honest maths

Price from cost, never from a guess. Build every unit up from its parts. Here is the full cost stack for one veg lunch thali; substitute your own numbers.

Cost line	How to work it out	Example (per thali)
Ingredients	Weekly grocery spend divided by meals cooked	Rs. 38
Packaging	Cost per box or tiffin, plus a label	Rs. 6
Fuel and gas	Monthly gas and power divided by meals	Rs. 4
Delivery	Fuel or rider cost divided by meals on the run	Rs. 6
Spoilage and wastage	About 5-8% of ingredient cost	Rs. 3
Your time	Decide an hourly rate and apply it	Rs. 12
Total cost	Sum of the above	Rs. 69

If the market price for a comparable thali is Rs. 90, your contribution is Rs. 21 a meal - about 23%. That is workable direct. It is not workable if an app takes 25% of the customer price and you keep the rest. Which is why the next section matters.

Price for the channel you sell on

The same meal must be priced differently for each channel, because each channel takes a very different cut.

Channel	Typical cut	What that means for you
Direct (WhatsApp, Instagram, phone)	0%	Highest margin; your price can be the market price
ONDC via a seller app	About 3-5%	Near-direct margin with app reach; strong for volume
Swiggy / Zomato	About 18-30%, plus 18% GST on the commission	Convenience and reach at a real cost; price the app menu higher than your direct menu
Corporate / B2B	0%, but invoiced monthly	Volume, predictable, needs GST invoices for most buyers

A simple rule: set your direct price as the anchor, add the platform's commission plus a small buffer to your app price, and never let the app price be lower than your direct price. If you cannot make the app price work after commission, that menu item is not an app item.

Three worked examples

These are models, not promises. Change the numbers to match your city and menu.

Example	Volume	Revenue / month	Cost / month	Net before tax
Tiffin service, 30 subscribers	30 x Rs. 2,800 (lunch, 22 days)	Rs. 84,000	Rs. 55,000	Rs. 29,000
Cloud kitchen from home	15 orders a day x Rs. 220 x 26 days	Rs. 85,800	Rs. 62,000	Rs. 23,800

Example	Volume	Revenue / month	Cost / month	Net before tax
Home bakery, weekend orders	24 cakes x Rs. 650	Rs. 15,600	Rs. 8,600	Rs. 7,000

Notice what drives the net figure. The tiffin example wins on volume and no commission; the cloud kitchen loses margin to app commission and delivery; the bakery has the highest margin per item but the lowest volume. Most successful home food businesses run two of these at once - a subscription base for steady cash and an order-based line for margin.

Subscription or per-order?

A subscription gives you predictable cash and lets you buy and cook to a plan; per-order sales give you higher margin per item but unpredictable volume. The strongest home food businesses run both - a subscription base for the steady floor of income, and per-order items (weekend specials, cakes, festival boxes) for the upside. Set a simple cancellation policy: 48 hours' notice, with any paid days carried forward. Predictable beats clever.

Menu engineering: keep the items that earn

Once you have a month of orders, rank every item by two numbers - margin per unit and how often it sells. Four outcomes decide everything:

	Sells often	Sells rarely
High margin	Your stars - feature them, never remove them	Promote them; if they still do not sell, cut them
Low margin	Re-price or re-engineer the recipe to raise margin	Cut them; they cost you time and cash

Home cooks instinctively keep the dish they are proud of. Customers keep the dish that earns. Cut the slow, low-margin items, and use the freed-up time to make your two or three stars faster and more consistent.

When and how to raise prices

- Raise on evidence, not on a bad month: when ingredient cost has risen for two months running, or when you are turning customers away.
- Give notice. Tell subscribers 30 days ahead and explain the one line that moved.
- Raise in one step, not in dribbles - repeated small increases annoy customers more than one clear one.
- Protect loyalty: hold the old price for your earliest subscribers for a few months, and they will defend you to everyone.

Part 6 - Getting Customers, Channel by Channel

The channel map

Channel	Cost to you	Best for	Watch out for
WhatsApp direct	Free	Subscriptions, repeat orders	You must build the list yourself
Instagram	Free (organic)	Cakes, premium and visual products	Reach depends on consistency
Swiggy / Zomato	18-30% commission	Instant reach, new customers	Commission and discount pressure
ONDC	About 3-5%	Volume with near-direct margin	Newer network; fewer buyers in some cities
Corporate / B2B	Free	Steady bulk volume	Needs GST invoices and reliability

Direct: WhatsApp and Instagram

Direct channels are where home food businesses make their best margin, because no one takes a cut. Build a WhatsApp Business profile with your FSSAI number in the description, a digital menu, and a weekly message with the next week's menu. On Instagram, post consistently - a clean photo of one dish, a short reel of the cooking, and a clear order instruction. The goal is not followers; it is a list of people who order every week.

Swiggy and Zomato

Both platforms onboard home kitchens. Expect to submit your FSSAI certificate, PAN, bank details or a cancelled cheque, a menu with prices and photos, and GST details if applicable. Swiggy may send someone to verify your premises. Approval commonly takes one to two weeks. Two practical points: your FSSAI name must match your PAN and bank account, or onboarding stalls; and for higher-risk menus - meat, seafood or dairy-heavy - some platforms ask for a State licence regardless of your turnover. Confirm your menu's requirement with the platform's onboarding team before you file.

ONDC: lower commission, how to join

The Open Network for Digital Commerce is a government-backed, open network - not an app - where you list once and can be visible across many buyer apps. Onboarding is free and happens through a 'seller network participant' app; for food, common ones include eSamudaay, uEngage and GoFrugal, with Magicpin as the largest food buyer app. You need PAN, a bank account, Aadhaar, and - for food - a mandatory FSSAI number. The draw is economics: ONDC food commissions have run around 3-5%, against 18-25% on the big two, which can be the difference between a thin and a healthy margin at the same volume.

B2B: offices, hostels, PGs and corporates

One office or hostel account can equal twenty individual customers, and pays on an invoice rather than per order. Target the places inside your delivery radius: PGs and hostels for student tiffins, corporate parks for lunch subscriptions, and small offices for daily snack or meal plans. Most B2B buyers want a GST invoice, so once your turnover justifies registration this channel opens fully. Reliability - same time, same standard, every day - wins and keeps these accounts.

A 30-day customer plan

1. Week 1: Open WhatsApp Business and Instagram; post three dishes; get ten prepaid testers.
2. Week 2: Convert testers into a small subscription; start one fixed delivery route.
3. Week 3: Apply to one app (ONDC first for margin, or Zomato for reach) and prepare photos.
4. Week 4: Approach two offices or hostels inside your radius with a one-page offer.

Photography and copy that sell

- Shoot in natural daylight, near a window, with the dish on a plain surface - a clean photo beats an expensive camera.
- Take one hero shot per dish: the best-looking portion, plated simply, with no clutter in frame.
- Show honest portions. A photo that oversells the plate earns one order and loses the second.
- Put the price and the order instruction in the caption, not buried in the comments.
- Post your weekly menu every Sunday at the same time - customers plan a week ahead, not a day.
- Collect and repost genuine customer messages; one real testimonial beats any claim you write.

Part 7 - Money, Tax and Records

Keep business money separate

Open a current account in the business name as soon as you have your FSSAI certificate and Udyam number. Pay every business expense from it and take every receipt into it. This one habit makes tax filing, loan applications and platform onboarding dramatically simpler, and it stops the slow leak of personal spending into business cash.

Presumptive tax: the simplest legal route

Small food businesses rarely need a full set of audited accounts. The presumptive scheme lets you declare a fixed percentage of turnover as profit and skip detailed books and the tax audit. For the tax year 2026-27 the old Section 44AD now sits inside Section 58 of the Income-tax Act, 2025, but the numbers are unchanged:

Parameter	Position for tax year 2026-27
Deemed profit on banked / UPI / card receipts	6% of that turnover
Deemed profit on cash receipts	8% of that turnover
Turnover limit	Rs. 2 crore (Rs. 3 crore if cash receipts are 5% or less)
Who can use it	Resident individual, HUF or partnership firm (not an LLP)
Books and audit	Not required, provided you declare at least the deemed profit
Return form	ITR-4
The trap	Opt out within five years by declaring lower profit, and you are barred from the scheme for the next five years

Source: Section 44AD, Income-tax Act, 1961, and Section 58, Income-tax Act, 2025. Because the 6% rate applies only to the banked share of turnover, collecting through UPI and bank transfer lowers the income you are taxed on - a real reason to go cashless beyond convenience.

GST returns if you are registered

If your turnover crosses Rs. 20 lakh and you register, expect to file monthly or quarterly returns and one annual return. If you are below the threshold and selling through Swiggy or Zomato, remember that the platform pays the 5% on app orders under Section 9(5) - you still report those supplies in your returns. When in doubt, a short consultation with a chartered accountant costs far less than a notice. Tax rules are complex and personal; treat this chapter as orientation, not as advice.

TDS, invoices and getting paid

- Register your PAN with each platform. Without it, TDS can be deducted at a higher rate instead of the normal 1% for e-commerce payouts.
- For B2B clients, issue a simple GST invoice once registered - most corporates cannot pay without one.
- Keep a running ledger of who owes you what; for subscriptions, collect in advance to protect your cash.
- Under MSME rules, a registered micro or small enterprise's buyer must pay within 45 days - and the MSME Samadhaan portal is where you enforce it.

Insurance and risk

A single food-poisoning complaint can cost more than a year of profit. Consider a small business or product-liability cover once you are selling at volume, and keep public-liability in mind if you ever host or cater events. Insurance is not mandatory for a home kitchen, but it is the cheapest way to sleep well while you grow.

Your monthly money routine

Thirty minutes on the first of every month keeps the business honest. Do these six things in order:

1. Reconcile the bank account: match every platform payout and direct transfer to an order.
2. Total the month's food, packaging and delivery cost from your receipts.
3. Compute margin per channel - direct, app and B2B - so you can see which one really earns.
4. Set aside tax. With presumptive taxation, roughly 6-8% of turnover is deemed profit, so keep the tax on that figure aside now rather than in March.
5. Review your top five customers and your worst five delivery days; fix the pattern, not the day.
6. Update your menu and prices if two or more cost lines have moved.

Part 8 - Funding and Government Support

You do not need a large loan to start - most home food businesses begin for under Rs. 25,000. But when you want to add a second kitchen, a freezer or a delivery vehicle, government schemes offer cheaper money than any informal lender. These are the four that matter.

MUDRA loans

Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana gives collateral-free loans to non-farm micro and small enterprises through banks, RRBs, small finance banks and NBFCs. There are four tiers:

Category	Loan amount
Shishu	Up to Rs. 50,000
Kishore	Rs. 50,001 to Rs. 5 lakh
Tarun	Rs. 5 lakh to Rs. 10 lakh
Tarun Plus	Rs. 10 lakh to Rs. 20 lakh (for those who have repaid a Tarun loan)

Apply through any member bank or online via the Jan Samarth portal. There is no processing fee for Shishu and Kishore, and loans are covered by the Credit Guarantee Fund for Micro Units.

PMFME: the 35% subsidy for micro food units

The PM Formalisation of Micro Food Processing Enterprises scheme, run by the Ministry of Food Processing Industries, is the single most relevant scheme for anyone making packaged or value-added food - pickles, masalas, snacks, bakery goods. It offers a credit-linked capital subsidy of 35% of eligible project cost, capped at Rs. 10 lakh per unit, with a minimum 10% beneficiary contribution and the rest as a bank loan. Self-help groups can get seed capital of Rs. 40,000 per member, and groups can receive grants of up to 50% for branding and marketing. Applications go through your State Nodal Agency.

Stand-Up India, CGTMSE and women-led benefits

- **Stand-Up India** offers Rs. 10 lakh to Rs. 1 crore to at least one woman and one SC/ST entrepreneur per bank branch, for greenfield enterprises.
- **CGTMSE** provides collateral-free credit guarantee; women-led enterprises get enhanced coverage of up to 90%, against 75% for others, and a 10% relaxation in the guarantee fee.
- **PMEGP** can give a subsidy of 15-35% on project cost for new manufacturing or service units.

Which one to use when

Your need	Best fit
Start with under Rs. 50,000	MUDRA Shishu (collateral-free)
Grow a tiffin or cloud kitchen to Rs. 5 lakh	MUDRA Kishore or Tarun
Make and package food products	PMFME 35% subsidy (with a bank loan)
Buy a vehicle or bigger equipment	MUDRA Tarun Plus or CGTMSE-backed loan
You are a woman founder scaling up	Stand-Up India plus the enhanced CGTMSE cover

Part 9 - Scaling from Rs. 5 Lakh to Rs. 1 Crore

A home food business can reach a crore in revenue without ever leaving a Basic FSSAI Registration - that is the practical effect of the April 2026 reform. The path is not one big jump; it is four checkpoints, each of which proves something before the next.

The four checkpoints

1. **50 paying subscribers within 90 days.** This proves the product and the price. If you cannot reach fifty with effort, fix the product before scaling anything.
2. **One repeatable daily or weekly routine by six months.** Same menu cycle, same delivery window, same standard - the discipline that lets you hand work to someone else.
3. **A first hire or a second channel by month nine.** Either a kitchen helper or a rider, or a second sales channel, so the business is not limited by your own hours.
4. **Costing and records in place before revenue nears Rs. 1.5 crore.** Past that line a State licence applies, and clean books make the upgrade and any loan straightforward.

Your first hire

Hire the task that costs you the most time, not the task you enjoy least. For most cooks that is either prep and packing, or delivery. A part-time helper for four hours a day is usually the first hire; a rider comes next. Pay fairly and formally - a Shop and Establishment registration applies once you employ staff, and it protects you both.

From home kitchen to commissary

You move out of the home kitchen when volume, not ambition, forces it - typically when you are routinely turning orders away or your delivery radius has grown past one run. A small commissary or a shared kitchen lets you add capacity without a restaurant's rent. Plan the move in the quiet season, and re-file your FSSAI details for the new address before you cook there.

Brand and trademark

Your name is the only asset a platform cannot take away. Register a trademark for it once you are confident it is the name you will keep - it is inexpensive for a single class, and MSMEs get a 50% subsidy on the filing fee. Use one name consistently across your packaging, app listing and social profiles; a mismatched name is also a common cause of app-onboarding rejection.

Packaged goods: the second income stream

Cooked meals are limited by your kitchen's daily capacity. Packaged products - a signature masala, a pickle, a biscuit - are not. Once your fresh business is stable, a shelf-stable product can be made in batches, sold on marketplaces, and shipped nationwide, with far better margins and no delivery radius. This is also the point at which PMFME's 35% subsidy and a State or Central FSSAI licence become relevant.

Part 10 - Risks, Penalties and Scams

Penalties you must avoid

Problem	Consequence
Selling food without FSSAI registration	Section 63, FSS Act: imprisonment up to six months and fine up to Rs. 5 lakh; the Jan Vishwas Act, 2023 raised the penalty to up to Rs. 10 lakh
Selling food not of the nature, substance or quality demanded	Penalty up to Rs. 5 lakh under the FSS Act
Expired or suspended licence pulled from an app	Immediate delisting; penalty of Rs. 100 a day for an expired FSSAI licence
Failing to register for GST when required	Section 122, CGST Act: penalty of 10% of tax due, minimum Rs. 10,000

If something goes wrong with the food

Treat any complaint about illness seriously and immediately. Stop selling the suspect item, keep the batch records, and respond to the customer with care rather than defensiveness. Preserving trust is faster and cheaper than winning an argument. Records of what you cooked, when, and from which ingredients are your protection - keep them simple but keep them.

Scams aimed at home food businesses

- Fake 'Udyam' or 'MSME registration' websites that charge a fee for a service that is free. The only official portal is udyamregistration.gov.in.
- Agents promising a fast FSSAI licence for a large upfront fee. You can file on FoSCoS yourself for Rs. 100 at Basic Registration.
- 'Bulk order' frauds - a large first order from an unknown buyer who pays only after delivery, then disappears. Take a deposit on large first orders.
- Fake delivery-app onboarding calls that ask for an OTP or a payment to 'activate' your listing. Legitimate platforms never ask for an OTP.

Part 11 - Your 90-Day Action Plan

The 90-day calendar

Window	Focus	Done when
Days 1-7	Validate the idea (Part 2)	Five testers, four would reorder
Days 8-14	Society consent and FSSAI filing	FSSAI application submitted
Days 15-21	Udyam registration and first ten testers	Udyam number received
Days 22-30	Kitchen setup, packaging, costing	Cost per unit known
Days 31-45	Open direct channels, start first route	Fifteen paying customers
Days 46-60	Apply to one app; approach one B2B account	App listing live
Days 61-75	Tighten delivery and menu; track waste	90% on-time delivery
Days 76-90	Review numbers; decide on the next hire or channel	Written review completed

Master compliance checklist

- FSSAI Basic Registration obtained and number displayed on menus, packs and listings.
- Udyam (MSME) registration completed.
- Society or landlord written consent for commercial cooking.
- Municipal trade licence if your city requires it.
- GST registration only if turnover crossed Rs. 20 lakh, or a B2B client needs invoices.
- Packaging labels carry the FSSAI number, ingredients, net weight, date and veg/non-veg mark.
- Business bank account opened and used for all business money.
- PAN registered with every platform to avoid higher TDS.

Cost calculator worksheet

Copy this table and fill your own numbers before you set a price.

Cost line	Your figure
Ingredients per unit	
Packaging per unit	
Fuel and power per unit	
Delivery per unit	
Spoilage allowance (5-8%)	
Your time per unit	
Total cost per unit	
Market price	
Margin per unit and %	

Menu and pricing worksheet

Item	Cost	Direct price	App price (after commission)	Margin %

Part 12 - Templates and Scripts You Can Copy

These are working drafts, not scripts to recite. Replace the bracketed parts with your own details, keep the tone warm and plain, and never remove the FSSAI number from anything a customer sees.

Your weekly WhatsApp broadcast

Sunday menu message

Good morning! Here is this week's menu (Mon-Sat): [list six dishes]. Lunch subscription is Rs. [price] a month for 22 days, or Rs. [per-day] for a single day. First trial meal is Rs. [trial price]. To order, send your name, delivery address and whether you want veg or non-veg. FSSAI Reg. No. [14-digit number].

Your Instagram bio and first post

Profile line

Home kitchen | Fresh [signature dish] made daily | FSSAI Reg. [number] | Delivery in [your two or three areas] | Order on WhatsApp: [link]. New menu every Sunday.

First post caption

We cook [dish] the way it is cooked at home - no shortcuts, no reheating. [One line about your story.] First trial meal Rs. [price]. Deliveries from [date] in [area]. Send us a message to book your slot.

The subscriber agreement, on one page

- Plan and price: [monthly plan], [number of meals], delivered on [days] at [time window].
- Payment: in advance, by [UPI / bank transfer], on or before the [date] of each month.
- Pause and cancellation: [48 hours] notice; paid days carry forward.
- Menu: a fixed rotating menu, published every Sunday, with one special day a week.
- Delivery: within [radius] of [area]; any delay informed the same morning.
- Contact: [your number]; FSSAI Reg. No. [number].

First-order confirmation

Confirmation reply

Thank you, [name]! Your order is confirmed for [day], [meal]. Delivery between [time] and [time] to [address]. Amount: Rs. [price], payable by [UPI / cash]. We will message you when it leaves the kitchen. FSSAI Reg. No. [number].

B2B proposal email

Short proposal

Subject: Daily lunch for [office / hostel], from Rs. [price] a meal. Hello [name], we run a home kitchen in [area] and supply fresh [veg / mixed] lunch to offices and hostels nearby. For [number] people, five days a week, our price is Rs. [rate] a meal, invoiced monthly, with a fixed menu and a fixed delivery window. We hold FSSAI Reg. No. [number] and can share references. Could we bring a trial lunch for your team on [day]?

A price-change note

Raising prices without losing trust

Dear [name], from [date] the [dish / plan] will cost Rs. [new price], up from Rs. [old price]. The reason is [one honest line, for example a rise in the cost of [ingredient]]. Your current plan stays at the old price until [date]. Thank you for trusting us with your meals.

Daily delivery checklist

- All meals packed in food-grade, sealed containers.
- Each pack labelled with the dish name, date and FSSAI number.
- Insulated bag loaded; hot items above 60 degrees C at dispatch.
- Route order set so the farthest stop is reached inside your delivery window.
- Payment collected or recorded for cash orders before the run.
- One line logged after the run: what sold, what was left, what went wrong.

Appendix A - Frequently Asked Questions

Do I really need an FSSAI licence to sell food from home?

Yes. The Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006 applies to anyone who manufactures, stores, sells or distributes food, with no exemption for home kitchens. Basic Registration costs Rs. 100 a year.

How much turnover can I do on Basic Registration now?

Up to Rs. 1.5 crore a year since 1 April 2026, raised from Rs. 12 lakh. Above that you move to a State Licence (up to Rs. 50 crore), and above Rs. 50 crore a Central Licence.

Do I have to renew my FSSAI registration?

No. Since 1 April 2026 registrations and licences have perpetual validity unless suspended, cancelled or surrendered. The annual fee still applies.

Can I use my home address for the FSSAI registration?

Yes. Your home address is accepted as the business address; an electricity bill or rent agreement serves as proof.

My society does not allow commercial activity. What now?

This is the real gate, not FSSAI. Get written consent on society letterhead naming your flat and the activity, or check your municipality's rules. A society can fine members, and a complaint can end the business.

Do I need GST to list on Swiggy or Zomato?

Not automatically. Restaurant service through these apps is a Section 9(5) supply, which is excluded from the mandatory e-commerce registration rule. You register only when turnover crosses Rs. 20 lakh (Rs. 10 lakh in special-category states), though platforms may ask for a GSTIN or an exemption declaration as a commercial condition.

Who pays the GST on my Swiggy and Zomato orders?

The platform. As the electronic commerce operator for restaurant service, it collects the 5% from the customer and pays it to the government on your behalf.

What GST rate applies to a cloud kitchen?

5% without input tax credit, the same as a restaurant. The 18% rate applies only to restaurants inside hotels classified as specified premises.

Is GST registration mandatory for Udyam?

No. Udyam registration needs only Aadhaar; GST is a separate matter decided by your turnover.

How do I price a meal I sell through an app?

Set your direct price as the anchor, add the platform's commission plus a small buffer for the app price, and never price the app below direct. If it does not work after commission, do not sell that item on the app.

What is the simplest way to handle tax on a small food business?

Presumptive taxation. Declare 6% of banked turnover and 8% of cash turnover as profit, up to Rs. 2 crore (Rs. 3 crore if cash receipts are 5% or less), and file ITR-4 - no detailed books or audit required.

What happens if I stop using presumptive tax after opting in?

If you declare a lower profit within five years, you are barred from the scheme for the next five years and must keep books. Choose it with the medium term in mind.

Can I get a loan to start without collateral?

Yes. MUDRA Shishu gives up to Rs. 50,000 collateral-free, rising through Kishore and Tarun to Rs. 20 lakh under Tarun Plus, and CGTMSE covers eligible loans without collateral.

Is there a government subsidy for food businesses?

PMFME gives a 35% credit-linked capital subsidy up to Rs. 10 lakh per unit for micro food processing units, with extra support for self-help groups.

Do women founders get extra support?

Yes. Stand-Up India offers Rs. 10 lakh to Rs. 1 crore to women and SC/ST entrepreneurs, and women-led enterprises get enhanced CGTMSE cover (up to 90%) and a lower guarantee fee.

Which is better - Swiggy/Zomato or ONDC?

They are different tools. Swiggy and Zomato bring reach at 18-30% commission; ONDC brings near-direct margin at roughly 3-5% through a seller app. Many businesses use both - apps for discovery, ONDC and direct for margin.

How long does FSSAI Basic Registration take?

Typically about 7-30 working days after a complete application on FoSCoS. Incomplete documents delay it, so prepare your ID, photo and address proof first.

What must be on my food packaging?

Your FSSAI number and logo, the product name, ingredients in descending order, net weight, manufacture and best-before dates, the veg or non-veg mark, and your name and address. Very small packs are exempt from some logos but not the veg or non-veg mark.

Do I need a trade licence as well as FSSAI?

Some cities - Hyderabad, Bengaluru and Mumbai among them - ask for a municipal trade licence when you list on delivery apps. Check your city's rule before you apply.

Can I sell on Instagram and WhatsApp without a licence?

No. Selling through social media does not exempt you from FSSAI. You need at least Basic Registration, and your FSSAI number should appear in your profile and on packaging.

How many customers do I need to be profitable?

There is no fixed number - it depends on your margin per order. Many tiffin services are comfortable at 30-40 subscribers; the worked example in Part 5 shows 30 subscribers producing about Rs. 29,000 a month before tax.

When should I move out of my home kitchen?

When volume, not ambition, forces it - typically when you are routinely turning orders away or your delivery radius has outgrown a single run. Move in the quiet season and re-file your FSSAI details for the new address.

How do I protect my brand name?

Register a trademark for the single class you sell in; MSMEs get a 50% subsidy on the filing fee. Use one name consistently across packaging, apps and social media.

What is the biggest mistake first-timers make?

Starting to sell before the paperwork and the costing are done. A licence you hold before your first order is cheap; the same licence discovered after a complaint is a penalty, and an unpriced menu quietly loses money on every order.

Appendix B - Sources and Further Reading

Every rule and figure in this guide is drawn from the primary sources below. Fees, thresholds and dates were current as of October 2026 - verify before you act.

Licensing and food safety

- FSSAI - Food Safety and Standards (Licensing and Registration of Food Businesses) Amendment Regulations, 2026 (Gazette notification dated 10 March 2026).
- FSSAI - Order dated 13 March 2026 on revised turnover thresholds, and the accompanying FAQs (effective 1 April 2026): fssai.gov.in.
- FSSAI - Press release on regulatory reforms, 13 March 2026.
- FoSCoS - Kind of Business eligibility sheet and registration portal: foscos.fssai.gov.in.
- FSSAI - Food Safety and Standards (Labelling and Display) Regulations, 2020 and their FAQs.
- Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006, Section 63; Jan Vishwas (Amendment) Act, 2023.

Tax

- CGST Act, 2017 - Sections 9(5) and 24(ix); Notification 17/2021-Central Tax (Rate).
- CBIC clarification on GST for food delivery services, October 2026.
- Income-tax Act, 1961 - Section 44AD; Income-tax Act, 2025 - Section 58 (presumptive taxation).

MSME, funding and market data

- Ministry of MSME - Udyam Registration portal and Udyam Assist Platform: udyamregistration.gov.in.
- MoFPI - PMFME scheme guidelines: pmfme.mofpi.gov.in.
- MUDRA - Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana categories and limits: mudra.org.in.
- CGTMSE and Stand-Up India scheme pages.
- Justdial search analysis for tiffin services (reported June 2026); Restaurant India (April 2026); IMARC Group Indian bakery market report (2026); India food service market projections to 2030.
- ONDC seller onboarding guides (official network and MSME state handbooks).

This guide is for information and education. It is not legal, tax or food-safety advice. Confirm current rules, fees and eligibility on the official portals and with a qualified professional before acting.

Appendix C - Glossary

Term	What it means
FSSAI	Food Safety and Standards Authority of India, the food regulator under the FSS Act, 2006
FBO	Food Business Operator - you, once you sell food to anyone
FoSCoS	Food Safety Compliance System, the portal where you register or take a licence
Basic Registration	The entry FSSAI tier, up to Rs. 1.5 crore turnover, about Rs. 100 a year
Perpetual validity	A licence that stays valid without a fixed renewal cycle (from 1 April 2026)
Udyam	The free government MSME registration that unlocks business benefits
CGST Act	Central Goods and Services Tax Act, 2017, which sets the GST rules
Section 9(5)	The rule making Swiggy and Zomato the payer of GST on restaurant orders
ECO	Electronic Commerce Operator - a platform such as Swiggy, Zomato or a seller app
ONDC	Open Network for Digital Commerce, a government-backed open selling network
PMFME	PM Formalisation of Micro Food Processing Enterprises, a 35% subsidy scheme
MUDRA	Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana, the collateral-free micro-loan scheme
CGTMSE	Credit Guarantee Fund Trust, which guarantees eligible loans without collateral
Presumptive tax	Declaring a fixed share of turnover as profit instead of keeping full books
TDS	Tax Deducted at Source - tax a payer withholds before paying you